

A I I N R E S E A R C H

Refining questions, grounding outlines, and building search strings — with AI.

Political Science Research Workshop • 90 minutes • Hands-on



What you'll walk out with

1

A refined research question

Move from a broad interest to a sharp, arguable question with named sub-questions.

2

An outline grounded in real sources

Built in NotebookLM, with citations you can click back to actual passages.

3

A working search string for EDS

Boolean syntax drafted by Gemini, refined live against EBSCO Discovery Service.

AI accelerates research — it doesn't replace it



Where AI helps

- Brainstorming and scoping
- Sub-question generation
- Vocabulary and synonyms
- Draft outlines and search strings

Where AI doesn't replace you

- Picking the angle — you choose, not Gemini
- Verifying every source it suggests
- Evaluating quality of results
- Doing the actual thinking and writing

Three cautions to carry into every AI session

1

Unverified citations

General LLMs invent sources that look real. Always click through to confirm the source exists and says what was claimed.

2

Hallucinated facts

Confident-sounding answers can be flat wrong. Cross-check claims against actual sources, especially for cases, statutes, and dates.

3

Privacy and uploads

Don't upload copyrighted PDFs you don't own, unpublished work, personal data, or anything sensitive — even into 'private' notebooks.

Refine your question with four prompts

Move from a broad interest to a researchable, arguable question with named sub-questions and key vocabulary.

1

Clarify scope

What are 4–5 different angles a political science paper could take on this topic?

2

Stress-test it

What are the strongest counter-arguments to my thesis?

3

Sub-questions

Give me 5 sub-questions I'd need to answer to argue this well.

4

Vocabulary

List key terms, synonyms, and disciplinary jargon, grouped by concept.

Watch out: if Gemini names a scholar or case, do not trust it yet — that's a Phase 2 job.

Build your notebook together

We build in parallel. I narrate; you follow on your own topic.

1

Create the notebook

Name it with your refined question.

3

Add 3–5 seed sources

Narrate why each one earns a spot.

5

Ask an analytical question

Click an inline citation — read the actual passage.

2

Talk about good sources

Peer-reviewed, policy reports, book chapters. Not blogs.

4

Generate a Briefing Doc

Synthesis grounded in your sources.

6

Generate an outline

Five sections, each grounded in your sources.

Privacy: only upload sources you have the right to use.

Why grounded beats general for synthesis

NotebookLM

Synthesis tool

- Cites only what's in your notebook
- Inline links to real passages
- Cannot make up sources
- Needs you to bring the sources

Gemini (general LLM)

Ideation tool

- Trained on everything; cites from memory
- May invent plausible-looking citations
- Great for angles, vocabulary, drafts
- Verify every source it names

Use the grounded tool to synthesize. Use the general tool to ideate.

Vocabulary into Boolean search strings

EXAMPLE

```
("autonomous weapon*" OR LAWS  
  OR "killer robot*")  
AND  
("international humanitarian law"  
  OR IHL OR "laws of war")  
AND  
(ethic* OR accountability  
  OR "meaningful human control")
```

Iteration moves

Too many results

Add another concept with AND, or narrow with a subject heading.

Too few results

Broaden a synonym group, drop a concept, or add truncation (*).

Use EDS-native tools

Subject term suggestions, field tags (SU, TI, AB).

AI drafts the string. You refine it inside the database.

THE WORKFLOW

Gemini to refine → NotebookLM to ground → EDS to find → loop back.

1

Verify every citation

AI suggests; you confirm.

2

Match tool to job

Grounded for synthesis. General for ideation.

3

Be deliberate uploading

Only what you have a right to use.

Questions? Stop by office hours or email your librarian.